Review and Remediation: Building a Sustainable Reparative Metadata Workflow



LIBRARIES

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2026 Upper Midwest User Group Conference
November 10, 2026

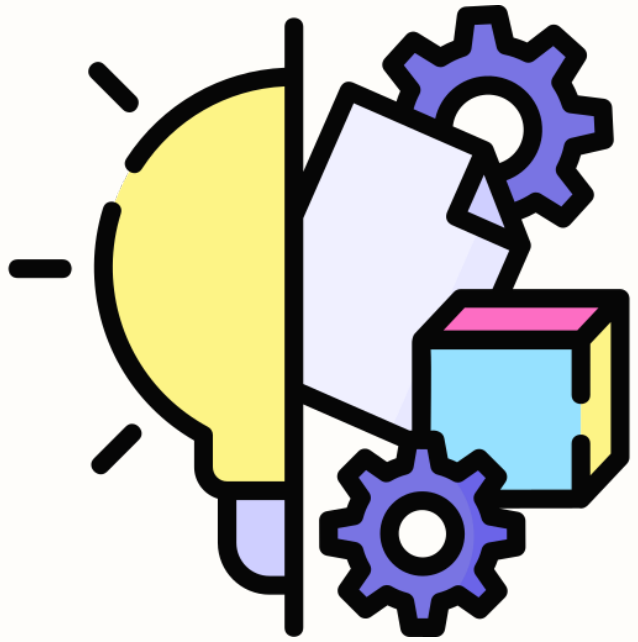
The Pilot Project

From April 2025 to August 2026

5 Library of Congress Subject Headings:

- Illegal immigration
- Problem children
- Sexual minorities
- McKinley, Mount (Alaska)
- America, Gulf of

Also addressed over 100 subject headings



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Goals

Develop a workflow to replace or supplement pejorative or outdated terms in our metadata

- Establish communication with stakeholders
- Utilize native Alma and Primo tools
- Implement changes across the NU consortium
- Ensure all changes are reversible



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Inspiration from other libraries

University of Toronto:
Indigenous Metadata Work

UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO LIBRARIES

Washington Research Library Consortium:
Reparative Cataloging CoP

Washington Research Library Consortium

Researching a new term

- New terms need to be current and respectful
- Learn what terms other libraries and communities use
- Referred to a variety of sources for new terms:
  - Peer-reviewed literature and databases
  - Committee reports and publications
  - Blogs, news stories, government agencies
  - Community groups



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Action

Determine an action to propose

- Replace
  - Direct 1:1 change
- Conditional
  - Change only in some instances
- Supplement
  - Add new term and retain LCSH
- Retain
  - Take no action



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Rationale examples 1 & 2

Although these terms refer to the broad group of people who enter or remain in a country without legal authorization, the use of "Illegal," "unauthorized," and "undocumented" imply different connotations and perspectives. Not all immigration starts out as illegal activity. UNL Libraries considers "Undocumented immigration" a more respectful and neutral term to use.

The Library of Congress decided to replace the pejorative "Illegal aliens" heading with a complex solution, two tandem headings, "Noncitizens" and "Illegal immigration." When the immigration heading is present on records with headings containing "Noncitizens" (or many related variations), UNL Libraries will change the heading to use "Undocumented immigrants" instead.

Rationale example 3

Library of Congress and the US Geological Survey (USGS) changed this term due to the signing of Executive Order 14172. As a US institution, it serves our users for our records to be consistent with the geographic names used by government agencies. However, there is an opportunity for confusion and a chance that resources become less discoverable for users who are unaware of the name change or its impact to LCSH. There has also been tension in both public and library discourse surrounding the reasons for the name change and the cultural impacts of the change. UNL Libraries will supplement records with both names.

Inform stakeholders

Communicate our intention with stakeholders

- Shared rationale statements for each change
- Requested feedback from Libraries staff, groups, and consortium members
- Consulted communities and subject experts
- Adapted when feedback called for it

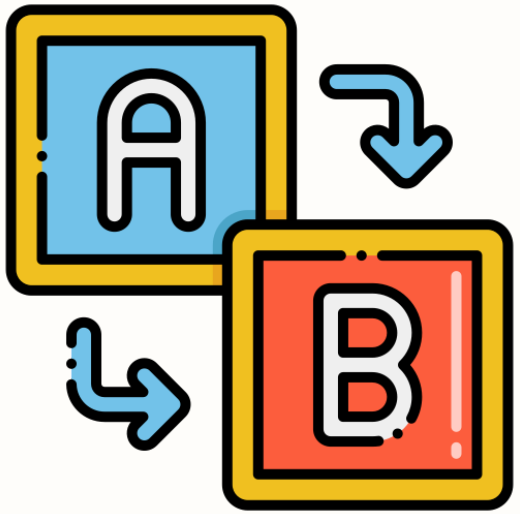


Interaction free icon created by nangicon - Flaticon

Making the change

At this point:

- ✓ Identified term needing reparative work
- ✓ Chose replacement/supplemental term
- ✓ Determined an action (replace, supplement, etc.)
- ✓ Gathered feedback from stakeholders



Choose the technical approach that best suits the desired action. Every approach is easily reversible!

Change free icon created by Flat Icons - Flaticon

Local Authority Records

A quick and simple way to make direct 1:1 changes

- Derived from existing LCSH records
- Added field to include rationale for the change
- Alma's Preferred Term Correction job automatically changes the subject headings
- Used for Illegal immigration, Sexual minorities, and Problem children



Authority free icon created by Flat Icons - Flaticon

5 ☐ **Problem children**

Record number: (DLC) sh 85107104
Seen from: Maladjusted children, Difficult children
See also: Behavior disorders in children, Children
Creation Date: 02/27/2012 03:54:39 CST
Modification Date: 06/10/2025 03:22:02 CDT

Vocabulary: LCSH
Originating System ID: sh 85107104

Record View

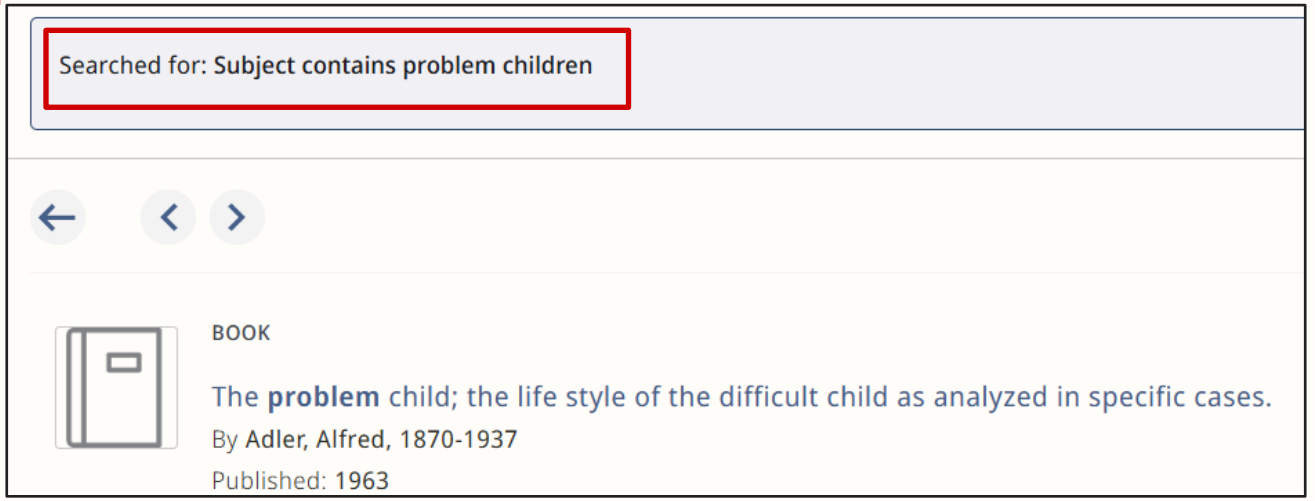
Copy to Network | Back | Copy

LDR	00732cz a2200181n 4500
001	98170919900000041
005	20240205152051.0
008	050506i| anannbabn |b ana
010	__ |a sh 85107104
035	## |a (DLC) sh 85107104
040	__ |a DLC |c DLC |d DLC |d ViU
150	__ |a Problem children
450	__ |a Difficult children
450	__ |a Maladjusted children
550	__ |w g |a Children
550	__ |a Behavior disorders in children
670	__ |a Difficult children, there is no such thing, c2003: |b t.p. introd. (children demonstrating behavioral disorders are being classified as educationally difficult to manage)
680	__ |i Here are entered works on children with behavior difficulties due to emotional instability or social environment.

010	__ |a sh 85107104
035	__ |a (DLC) sh 85107104
035	__ |a (LIBRARY_OF_CONGRESS)981709199000000041
040	__ |a DLC |c DLC |d DLC |d ViU
150	__ |a Children with behavioral problems
450	__ |a Problem children |5 NbU
450	__ |a Difficult children
450	__ |a Maladjusted children
550	__ |w g |a Children
550	__ |a Behavior disorders in children
667	__ |a “Problem children” is a term that was used in educational and psychological literature to describe children with behavior issues due to emotional instability or social environment. The literature has shifted to focus on the behavior rather than the nature of the children, making this term outdated. Current headings found in relevant databases include "behavior problems" and "problem behavior." UNL Libraries considers “Children with behavioral problems” to be a more respectful and neutral term and that it maintains parity with the terminology currently found in the relevant psychological and educational literature databases.
670	__ |a Difficult children, there is no such thing, c2003: |b t.p. introd. (children demonstrating behavioral disorders are being classified as educationally difficult to manage)
680	__ |i Here are entered works on children with behavior difficulties due to emotional instability or social environment.

Details

Title	The **problem** child; the life style of the difficult child as analyzed in specific cases.
Creator	Adler, Alfred, 1870-1937
Publisher	New York Capricorn Books
Creation Date	1963
Format	xvii, 172 p. 21 cm
Note	"The present volume was published in German in 1930, as one of the volumes on Die Technik der Individualpsychologie ... and bore the subtitle Die Seele des schwererziehbaren Schulkindes."
Subject	**Children with behavioral problems**
Series	A Capricorn giant original, 228
Source	Library Catalog



https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991017618739706387

Normalization Rules

Some LCSH have multiple meanings or contexts that make a direct one-to-one change unsuitable.

- Normalization rules can change context-specific subject headings
- Used for the subject headings "Noncitizens" only when it appeared in records alongside "Illegal immigration"
- Rule is applied quarterly to catch newly added records



Book free icon created by Smashicons - Flaticon

650 Noncitizens

Rule | Normalization | Drool

```
rule "Change 650.a Noncitizens to 650.a Undocumented immigrants when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
   (exists "650.a.Noncitizens*") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration*|Illegal immigration*")
then
   replaceContents "650.a.Noncitizens" with "Undocumented immigrants"
end


rule "Change 650.a Children of noncitizens to 650.a Children of undocumented immigrants when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
   (exists "650.a.Children of noncitizens.") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration.|Illegal immigration.")
then
   replaceContents "650.a.Children of noncitizens" with "Children of undocumented immigrants"
end


rule "Change 650.a Church work with noncitizens to 650.a Church work with undocumented immigrants when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
   (exists "650.a.Church work with noncitizens.") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration.|Illegal immigration.")
then
   replaceContents "650.a.Church work with noncitizens" with "Church work with undocumented immigrants"
end


rule "Change 650.a Noncitizen children to 650.a Undocumented immigrant children when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
   (exists "650.a.Noncitizen children.") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration.|Illegal immigration.")
then
   replaceContents "650.a.Noncitizen children" with "Undocumented immigrant children"
end
```

Details

Title	Alien smuggling : management and operational improvements needed to address growing problem : report to congressional committees
Creator	United States. General Accounting Office
Publisher	Washington, D.C. P.O. Box 37050, Washington, D.C. 20013 : The Office
Creation Date	2000
Format	35 p. : ill. ; 28 cm
Note	Cover title "May 2000." "GAO/GGD-00-103." "B-283952"--P. 1
Subject	**Undocumented immigrants** -- Government policy -- United States Smuggling -- United States -- Prevention **Undocumented immigration** -- Government policy -- United States **Undocumented immigrants**
Genre	Electronic books
Source	Library Catalog

https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991005416739706387

Normalization Rules

In some cases, we deemed it appropriate to supplement LCSH rather than replace them.

- Normalization rules added our supplemental headings in records that had specific LCSH
- This approach was used for the LCSH "America, Gulf of" and "McKinley, Mount (Alaska)" to support discoverability
- Added subject term in a local subject field (690)

650 Gulf of America Mount McKinley

Rule | Normalization | Drool

```
rule "Add 690.a.Mexico, Gulf of when 651.a.America, Gulf of*"
when
   (exists "651.a.America, Gulf of*")
then
   addField "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of" if (not exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of*")
   addSubfield "690.5.NbU" if (exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of")
   addSubfield "690.9.local" if (exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of")
   correctDuplicateSubfields "690" "59"
   correctDuplicateFields "690"
end

rule "Add 690.a.Mexico, Gulf of when 650.z.America, Gulf of*"
when
   (exists "650.z.America, Gulf of*")
then
   addField "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of" if (not exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of*")
   addSubfield "690.5.NbU" if (exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of")
   addSubfield "690.9.local" if (exists "690.a.Mexico, Gulf of")
   correctDuplicateSubfields "690" "59"
   correctDuplicateFields "690"
end
```

```
rule "Add 690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska), Gulf of when 651.a.McKinley, Mount (Alaska)*"
when
   (exists "651.a.McKinley, Mount (Alaska)*")
then
   addField "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)" if (not exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)*")
   addSubfield "690.5.NbU" if (exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)")
   addSubfield "690.9.local" if (exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)")
   correctDuplicateSubfields "690" "59"
   correctDuplicateFields "690"
```

Details

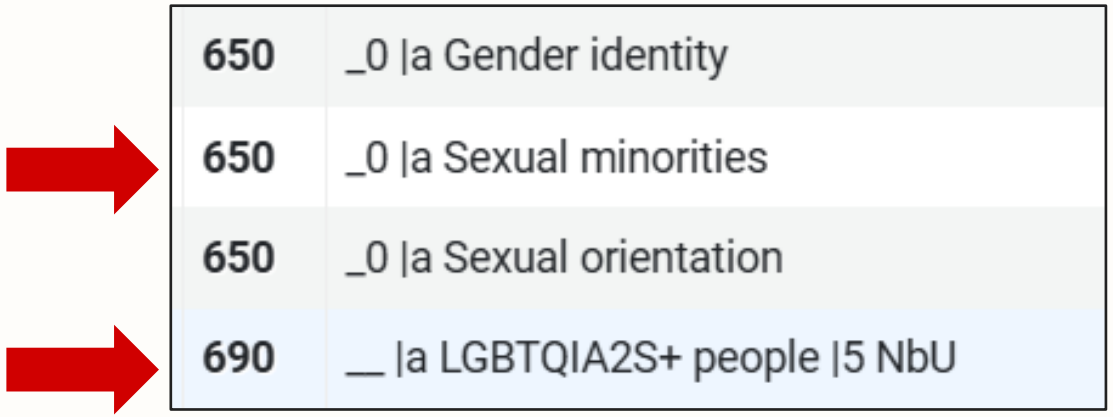
Title	**The ascent of Denali (Mount McKinley)** : a narrative of the first complete **ascent** of the highest peak in North America
Creator	Stuck, Hudson, 1863-1920
Publisher	Lincoln : University of Nebraska Press
Creation Date	1989
Format	xix, 188 p., 34 leaves of plates : ill., maps ; 21 cm
Note	Reprint. Originally published: New York : Scribner, 1914 "A Bison book."
Subject	Stuck, Hudson, 1863-1920 -- Travel -- Alaska -- **McKinley, Mount** Mountaineering -- Alaska -- **McKinley, Mount** **McKinley, Mount** (Alaska) Denali, **Mount** (Alaska)
Source	Library Catalog

https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991011224519706387

Challenges: Community Zone (CZ)

We are unable to change existing metadata in records sourced from the Alma CZ

- Normalization rules can supplement CZ records with preferred subject headings
- Subjects are added in a local subject field (690)
- LCSH are hidden from display using DEI exclude list in instances of direct 1:1 changes



650	_0 |a Gender identity
650	_0 |a Sexual minorities
650	_0 |a Sexual orientation
690	__ |a LGBTQIA2S+ people |5 NbU

Details

Title	**Gender Is Really Strange.**
Creator	Goetz, Teddy G., author.
Contributor	Standing, Sophie, illustrator.
Publisher	London : Jessica Kingsley Publishers
Creation Date	2023
Format	1 online resource (42 pages) text file rdaft
Subject	**Gender** identity Sexual orientation LGBTQIA2S+ people

https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991030440199106387

Challenges: CDI Records

The only tool capable of impacting Central Discovery Index (CDI) records is Alma's DEI exclude list

- The DEI exclude list can remove and replace subject terms and add annotations to subjects in display
- It is limited in function and is only useful for direct 1:1 changes in CDI records
- Using it will apply to all records, not just CDI

Results

LCSH	Repaired subject heading
~~Illegal immigration~~	Undocumented immigration
~~Problem children~~	Children with behavioral problems
~~Sexual minorities~~	LGBTQIA2S+ people
McKinley, Mount (Alaska)	Denali, Mount (Alaska)
America, Gulf of	Mexico, Gulf of

Next Steps & Resources

Although the pilot project has finished, the work continues.

- A new group will convene to continue identifying problematic and replacement subject headings
- We are developing a submission form for users to let us know if they find a subject heading in need of reparative work
- We are maintaining a GitHub repository containing our normalization rules and workflows

Resources

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Pedersen, Jordan, and Juliya Borie. "University of Toronto: Indigenous Metadata Work." Webinar, Improving Access to Indigenous Collections Through Classification and Metadata, NASIG, August 14, 2024. https://youtu.be/k88z3is1Jio.

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Thank you!



https://go.unl.edu/acme-presentations

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